the case of the TUESDAY GHOST



a sherlock holmes mystery for the modern pipeline

cut along the dashes

the moral

a key outlives the person who made it.

keys should expire, like milk. write down what each one opens, and when it ends.

> case file for you: is there a key in your system that was last rotated *never*?

(tuesdays were saved. watson brought tacos.)

elementary

holmes didn't guess. he followed the key, and in an old folder he found a note:



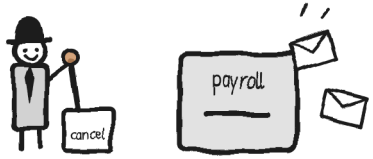
"please give each job its own key."
— j. moriarty, 2015

so they did. the weekly job went on a diet. watson gave every key an end date.

next tuesday, the build passed. everyone got paid.

too fast

"cancel it!" said lestrade, and cancelled moriarty's key himself.

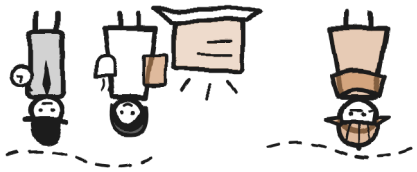


the build passed. then payroll ran. nobody got paid.

the key opened more than one door.

2 a.m., in the fog

the build had failed again. the ops channel lit up like halloween.



holmes (site reliability) was summoned. **watson** (compliance) brought tea and her key register. **lestrade** (management) wanted an ETA.

"fix it," said lestrade, "or no more tuesdays."

the clues



1. it only ever fails on tuesdays.
2. deploy before lunch in singapore: fine. after lunch: kaboom.
3. the logs rotate into a file called `ghost.log`.
4. `ghost.log` is completely empty.

"curious," said holmes. "very curious."

the usual suspects

a flaky network? a permissions mix-up? a YAML file cursed by one missing space? holmes ruled them out, one by one.

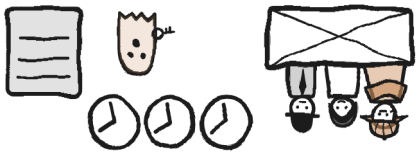


then watson opened her register. one key was last rotated: *never*. it was signed *j. moriarty, 2014*.

moriarty left ten years ago.

the stakeout

monday night, they waited up, every clock set to UTC.



at **05:07** on tuesday, a weekly job woke up and logged in with moriarty's key. it ate all the memory, then tidied the logs on its way out. that's why `ghost.log` was empty.

the ghost had a key.